

PUSL3190 Computing Project Final Report Submission

Final Report - Report structure

The report documents your project's products and the processes that supported their development. It will normally conform to the following structure:

- Title [Front Cover] page (template available on the portal)
- Acknowledgements
- Abstract (see the separate document on writing your abstract)
- Table of Contents
- List of Figures and Tables (if applicable)
- Main body of report
 - Introduction
 - Chapters
 - End-project report (and Recommendations, if applicable)
 - Project post-mortem
 - Conclusions
- Reference List
- Bibliography
- Appendices – in this order please
- User Guide (As a minimum this should indicate how the product can be installed for demonstration, including details of the (minimum) required platform specification. If appropriate, there should also be information on how the system can be used or operated.)
- Project Source Code Link
- GitHub commit history along with the GitHub repository link.
- PID
- Interim reports
- Records of supervisory meetings
- Other material such as designs, preliminary designs, test results, etc.

Main body content

The variety of projects precludes a definitive statement on the content of a project report, but here's one suggestion for the main body:

- Introduction
- Background, objectives & deliverables
- Literature review (if applicable)
- Method of approach
- Requirements
- End-project report

- Project post-mortem
- Conclusions

These are only suggestions, and the contents of your particular report should be discussed with your supervisor.

General advice on content

- Allow yourself plenty of time to write your report and then allow 50% extra on top of that.
- Polish, polish, polish and then polish some more. Don't hand in the first draft (or even the tenth!) Many first/second/third drafts are often dreadful.
- Describe your work at a suitable level. The standard advice is that it should be written at a level that could be read by a (good) final stage student. The best reports display author maturity and demand it from their reader.
- Please put some screen shots in your main body ... but too many can be tedious.
- You can gain credit for what you did as well as what you produced. The report should therefore describe both your deliverables and the processes by which they were created. Especially consider the activities you carried out that are not obviously visible from the final product. For example, consider requirements elicitation: which methods did you use? Show the reader that you're aware of recognized techniques rather than making it up as you go along: why did you choose them? Describe their enactment and record their findings. What particular problems/challenges did you encounter, and how did you solve them? What parts of your work do you think are particularly worthy of credit: bring these out in your report?
- Do not include significant chunks of code in your report ... instead put them on the disk which is attached to the report.

The use of appendices

- The appropriate use of appendices is critical. Firstly, assume that your reader will not read your appendices: in other words, make sure that the main body of the report is a self-contained description of your project (at least at some level of abstraction): If the reader needs to read something in order to understand your project, then put at least a summary of it in the main body.
- Some things will be too voluminous or detailed to put in the main body but may be important to the reader's understanding: put a summary in the main body, and the full blown version in an appendix. For example, the reader does not want to read pages of test results – put a summary of the testing processes and results in the main body, and the full blown test results in an appendix.
- Material that relates to the wider context (particularly if it is voluminous) is a good candidate for inclusion in an appendix. For example, you might be developing an eCommerce system for a client, and have written a summary describing your

client's competitor websites. Generally speaking, the main body needs to focus on your project.

- Another reason for putting material in an appendix is that it is too low level. For example the details of your DB normalisation would normally be in an appendix, with the final schema presented (perhaps as an ERD/LDS) in the main body of the report.
- Another example would be your choice of software development process. You might write a chapter discussing the pros and cons of the different processes available¹, and why you chose the one that you did. But this is not final stage work: put this chapter in an appendix, and put a brief summary in the main body. It is worth noting here that you also need to detail (in the main body) how the process was enacted in your project.
- Ditto for your choice of technologies.
- Another use of appendices can be to include earlier versions of designs: for example initial screen shots – even ones drawn by hand. These can be useful in your description of your process.

Secondly, assume that your reader will read your appendices: The quality of presentation in the appendices should be as good as in the main body. Furthermore, the appendices are not a dumping ground for miscellaneous material, and in particular, all appendices should be referenced/cited in the main body of the report; if they aren't, then you might consider why they are included at all.

End-project report

- An end-project report is produced (say for a Project Board or Client) as part of (and towards the end of) a project!
- Brief summary of the project and its achievements.
- Relist your project's objectives and critically (and ruthlessly) evaluate whether you met the objectives. Projects rarely go perfectly, and an inability to find any real criticism will possibly be met with some suspicion. If your work is for a real client, try to involve them in this evaluation (and include details of their feedback).
- Realisation of business objectives (either to-date or planned).
- Changes made during the project, their reasons and effects.

The post-mortem

A post-mortem is often carried out shortly after a project is over. Looking back (and indeed standing back), you can now evaluate/critically appraise any aspect of the project (although you do not need to repeat any evaluations that were made as part of the project/end-project report). For example:

- Were the project objectives the right ones to adopt?
- Was the product properly specified (in relation to the business objectives)?
- The relationship between the project and the client.
- Did the chosen development process the right one?
- Were the chosen technologies the right ones?
- Your own performance (try to be specific).
- Wider reflections on Client feedback.
- Generally, what lessons are to be learnt for the future.
- ☐ Etc., etc.

Conclusions:

Final, brief, summarising conclusions.

Final Report: Style

- The report should be professionally presented and word processed with (approx.) 1.15 line spacing on one side of good quality A4 paper. Pages should be numbered consecutively except for the title page.
- Sections and sub-sections should employ nested numbering, e.g., Section 1, sub-sections 1.1, 1.2, etc., sub-sub-sections 1.1.1, 1.1.2, etc. This is really important in helping the reader to follow the structure of your report.
- You should adhere to accepted norms regarding referencing, paraphrasing, and plagiarism. See the University guides in the FinalReportDemo folder.
- Use good grammar, and make sure that you understand the proper uses of punctuation symbols such as: comma, semi-colon, colon, and apostrophe. Avoid overly long sentences: 30 words is generally too long.
- Avoid unnecessary repetition.
- The standard academic style (to which you should conform) is past tense, third-person.
- Use passive forms when possible (e.g., ‘the software was tested’ not ‘I tested the software’).
- Try to be formal in style; avoid slang and colloquial language.
- Avoid being conversational in style. Avoid personal pronouns such as ‘I’, ‘me’, ‘my’, ‘we’, ‘you’, ‘he’, ‘she’ and try to avoid other personalisations such as ‘the author’, and ‘the student’. Do use phrases such as ‘this project’, ‘the program’, ‘the respondents’ (and do use ‘it’ or ‘they’ to avoid excessive repetitions of these). Refer to yourself (‘the author’ – possibly followed by ‘I’ or ‘my’) only when you are clearly stating your own personal opinion.

Final Deliverables

Final report

- The hard copy report should be comb-bound. The front cover template is available

in the DLE: The front cover must be white with black type. Front and back covers must be laminated.

- **The report word limit is *strictly* 10 000 words.** Your reference list, bibliography, and appendices are not included in the word count. We suggest that your report should be no less than 8000 words.
- Please include your project source code link in the appendix. (Upload your Source code to Plymouth OneDrive. Please note that you should provide access to the link for all users (evaluators), or you will get zero marks. Get the OneDrive link and copy and paste it into the Final Report). **Failing to include the source code link, you will receive a mark of ZERO for your project.**
- You should also upload an electronic (PDF) copy of your report to the DLE. Please upload a single PDF file.
- Rename the PDF file with your PU index number as follows,
Ex :- 1234567_Final_Report.pdf